

Assessed Coursework Coversheet

For use with *individual* assessed work

Student ID Number:	2	0	1	9	0	6	4	1	5
Module Code:	LUBS5579M								
Module Title:	Business Analytics and Decision Sciences Dissertation								
Module Leader:	Romain Crastes dit Sourd								
Declared Word Count:	1513								

Please read the following carefully and be accurate in your responses; they are all important:

	Delete as appropriate
By submitting this work I declare it is all my own work, other than where indicated by references. I have not colluded with others, re-submitted past work of my own, submitted any work done by others or by Generative AI unless indicated, or otherwise breached the University academic integrity rules. I understand that any discrepancies between this declaration and the assignment could result in an academic malpractice procedure. Read the full University of Leeds declaration of academic integrity here https://secretariat.leeds.ac.uk/wp-content/uploads/sites/109/2022/12/academic_integrity.pdf	YES
My declared word count is accurate and I have not attempted to mislead. I understand that making a fraudulent statement about word count could result in an academic malpractice procedure, and/or may impact the mark.	YES
I have applied for an extension but have not yet heard back on whether it is granted. I am submitting this paper in the knowledge that I may request to submit a later version when I hear back from the extension team. Markers should be aware that this may not be my final version of the assignment.	YES
I am aware of the GAI category for this assignment (delete opposite to show the correct one), and have adhered to the guidance for that category.	RED

Assignments should be submitted in time but will be accepted (with late penalties) up to 14 days after deadline

Late penalties = 5 marks per 24hours late

CONSUMER SHIFTING FROM OFFLINE TO E-COMMERCE BUSINESSES DURING COVID-19: A TEMPORARY FIX OR PERMANENT SHIFT?

INTRODUCTION:

The coronavirus, or COVID-19, pandemic was an unexpected and unprecedented event that affected the entire world. All sectors experienced the impact of this crisis. While the health sector was significantly affected, consumer purchasing behavior also changed dramatically. Before COVID-19, many people preferred shopping at traditional offline retail stores. However, during the pandemic, lockdowns and the need for social distancing made in-person shopping impossible. As a result, consumers began to shift to online shopping for everything, including essentials like groceries and medications. This marked a significant change in the e-commerce landscape. Even local shops recognized the necessity of adapting to this new reality by establishing a digital presence to survive. Although this transition was initially a necessary response, there is now an ongoing debate about whether these changes will be temporary or if the dynamics between offline and online markets have changed forever.

Before COVID-19, E-commerce platforms were still used but in a fancy way, like buying clothes that aren't available in local shops or finding exclusive items, etc. The e-commerce market was growing steadily as consumers started preferring technology over the old traditional style to do stuff, but the pandemic acted as a catalyst to accelerate this change from offline to online. There was huge growth in the e-commerce market as people tended to shop more when they were isolated.

Various patterns of consumer behavior did occur after the restrictions were reduced and lockdown was removed. Some of the consumers were happy to be back in the retail shops, shopping in their traditional way and socializing, but some consumers were happy to continue shopping online as it is easy, less time-consuming and also provides lots of variety customized to their preferences. Now the crucial question is: Did this pandemic change the overall retail market permanently, or will it gradually go back to 'before COVID-19 normal'?

This research proposal aims to explore the long-term implications of COVID-19 on the offline and online retail market. It will investigate whether the consumers who have changed their preferences will continue to do so or if they will revert to previous patterns. By analyzing consumers' preferences and industry trends and other factors like business strategies, this study will contribute to pre-pandemic and post-pandemic consumer preferences and how this will impact the retail market. And give an insight into the future trajectory of retail commerce. Through a comprehensive analysis of both qualitative and quantitative data, this research will determine whether e-commerce is going to stay or if traditional retail stores will regain their previous position. Therefore, this will not only contribute to academic literature on consumer behaviour but also offer beneficial guidance for businesses and marketers to navigate through the retail market and plan accordingly.

LITERATURE REVIEW:

The pandemic has influenced consumers' purchasing behaviour, especially in the retail area. This literature review examines the recent studies on the shift of consumers from offline to online platforms during COVID-19 and analyses whether it is a permanent or a temporary shift.

One of the studies investigated the online purchasing pattern in Japan during the pandemic where Inoue and Todo (2023) found that this trend to shift to e-commerce is a temporary shift as after the pandemic people in Japan started to revert to previous pattern of traditional shopping and online purchases started to decline but here in this study, they have only focused on Japan and didn't take account of young consumers and tech-savvy consumers and their patterns for long term purchasing behaviour. On the other hand, the study focusing on the US by Morales, Milagros has a more subtle viewpoint, indicating that most of the consumers were forced to adopt online shopping due to necessity and they would prefer to return to traditional offline shopping with social and sensory experience as the online shopping cannot completely provide the same experience in virtual platform. Although this study was conducted in 2021, which means that a lot has happened since, this study didn't consider the age factor (like millennials and GenZ) who are already inclined toward technology.

Some researchers argue that the pandemic just acted as a catalyst to a pre-existing move toward e-commerce rather than creating a whole new pattern of consumer behaviour. According to Kucharska et al. (2024), the usage of online retail increased during Covid due to necessity not by preference. Many consumers returned to their pre-pandemic shopping patterns after the health concerns subsided, indicating that this rise in e-commerce platforms is more of a temporary thing than a permanent shift. However, this study didn't investigate whether some industries (like grocery, fashion, etc) experienced more enduring e-commerce adoption than others.

Similarly, Dabija et al. (2024) examined the trend of online grocery shopping and discovered that shopping online is a temporary thing as online shopping may be convenient, but people won't change their habits only based on convenience, as in offline they are getting more advantages like fresh food and reasonable pricing, etc which they will only get in-person. But in this study, they have only focused on groceries, not on AI-driven personalized fashion or subscription-based services, which can highly influence consumers' behavior. This may enhance long-term consumer retention on e-commerce platforms.

However, most of the research done in this area either doesn't have a proper sample size or the data was collected over a long period where consumers' opinions changed over the years, which made the study irrelevant. Also, most of the papers didn't take age, demographic variation, and AI into consideration, which are all important factors for consumer behavior. No proper suggestion was given for offline retail shops to compete with the e-commerce market.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS:

Based on the gaps identified from the literature review, this study aims to explore the long-term impact of Covid-19 on consumer purchasing behavior, especially to analyse whether the shift to the e-commerce market is temporary or permanent.

Questions:

1. What are the factors that influenced consumers to shift from offline stores to online?
2. Have consumers continued shopping online post-pandemic, or have they returned to physical stores? If no, why not?
3. Are the factors still valid post-pandemic to stay on online platforms?
4. To what extent has the shift from offline retail stores to e-commerce during COVID-19 persisted in the post-pandemic era?
5. How have different consumer demographics (e.g., Millennials, Gen Z, and Baby Boomers) shown varying tendencies in retaining online shopping habits?
6. What strategies can traditional retail stores adopt to remain competitive in a post-pandemic world dominated by digital commerce?

RESEARCH OBJECTIVES:

- To understand the long-term impact of the pandemic on the consumer's purchasing behaviour shift from offline to online.
- To identify the key factors influencing this shift during Covid-19 and the factors that are still holding back consumers from going back to offline retail stores.
- To evaluate whether the factors that initially made them shift are still relevant during post-pandemic.
- To examine the impact of demographic variations (e.g., Millennials, Gen Z, and Baby Boomers) on online shopping retention.
- To explore strategies for offline retail stores to attract back the consumer to traditional in-person shopping.

DATA SOURCE:

This research will collect data from both primary and secondary data sources to ensure a comprehensive and complete analysis of e-commerce trends and consumer behavior.

- a) Primary data: The information will be collected through consumer surveys and in-depth interviews with a few retail store owners/staff to understand the whole scenario of pre-, post-, and during Covid-19 differences. And also, to understand consumer behavior.
- b) Secondary data: This information will be collected through already existing articles, research papers, government reports, and industry reports to provide a broader understanding of the whole trend and how it has impacted since the pandemic.

METHODOLOGY:

This research will employ a mixed-method approach as both quantitative and qualitative data will be collected.

- a) **Quantitative Analysis:** This will be the online survey conducted for consumers to analyze the age group, demographic variation, and other patterns for consumer behavior. It will have closed-end questions to measure and analyze which factors have more influence in the trend pre- and post-pandemic. The collected data will be analyzed using statistical tools such as regression analysis, correlation studies, and frequency distributions to identify significant trends and relationships.
- b) **Qualitative Analysis:** This will be the in-depth interviews with the retail business owners/staff to understand and get more insight into how consumers have shifted their patterns post-pandemic.
- c) **Comparative Analysis:** This will compare both pre-pandemic and post-pandemic shifts of consumers' purchasing patterns and preferences from offline to online markets.

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS:

The surveys and the interviews will be conducted autonomously as people may not want to be included in the research. Also, a detailed description of the research will be given as a disclaimer of what they are participating in, and they will also be asked for consent to use the information in the research, to mitigate any ethical issues.

LIMITATION:

Although a stratified sampling will be utilized, the sample size and the sample representation may not be up to the mark as it might not represent the global market. Even to capture the trends correctly is difficult as they tend to change pretty fast.

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